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MAOIST WOMEN BEING RELEASED IN EXCHANGE FOR POLICE OFFICER ATINDRANATH DATTA

the hostage swap, Kishenji achieved a massive political victory—he gained the villagers’ mandate for getting back their women in exchange for the hostage and ensured that villagers who had strayed from the Maoist support base returned. Not many people realise, especially the illiterate villagers, that the man himself had been surrounded by forces and the only way for him to escape capture was to have handed out this sop of a swap or kill the hostage.

Asim Chatterjee or “Kaka”, the legendary Naxalite leader of burning Bengal in the 1970s, who is now a shadow of his former self having reconciled himself to dominion status within the Left Front, feels woman power has always been and shall always be in the forefront of any communist struggle. “It is not as if our war of liberation did not have women in the ’70s. But their roles

were more moderate. They did not belong to army squads. But militancy for the sake of a party is not the basis of revolution. We had tried to make the masses rebel with us but the Maoists are using weapons to bring the masses with them. I am not in agreement with their class war. Theirs is not a people’s movement.”

The role of women in land struggles isn’t new. Says Chhoton Das, general secretary of the Committee for the Release of Political Prisoners, who is out on bail after being arrested on October 20 for supporting the Maoists, “The first incidents of violence and protests in Telengana and Tebhaga, two of the biggest communist movements in India, were led by women even if they were tokenism. In Singur and Nandigram, the women’s resistance was more pronounced. They came out with scythes and brooms and whatever

they could lay their hands on. Women in villages almost invariably realise the dangers lurking in uninhibited capitalism. Lalgah is just a logical outcome.” Das says that the villagers were the first to see that the Left Front rule was not progressive and not “Leftist at all”. He says, “Maybe they don’t understand the theory but they have a mother’s gut feeling to protect the family. The Left movement is dying and the Front misrule was only hastening the end. It is heartening to see the real Left returning once again.”

As is usual, the Left Front, and particularly the CPI(M), sees no reason to feel upset. Minister for Uplift of the Western Areas Sushanta Ghosh, a militant man who recently gave a call to comrades to rise in arms against the Maoists and set up a counter militia, dismisses the woman power. “What woman power are they talking about?” he asks. Ghosh’s remark is typical of the Left Front, which seems to believe that if a problem is ignored for long, it will simply go away. ■

“Maoists are using weapons to bring the masses with them. It’s not a people’s movement. I don’t agree with their war.”

ASIM CHATTERJEE, former Naxal leader in the 1970s